LEVONORGESTREL (EMERGENCY)

Within 72 h (best <24 h)
Double dose with enzyme inducers

CHEMICAL NAME (17α)-13-ethyl-17-hydroxy-18,19-dinorpregn-4-en-20-yn-3-one
CLASS Progestogen-only emergency contraceptive
TRADE NAMES Postinor · Plan B One-Step · Levonelle · NorLevo

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Emergency contraception after unprotected intercourse or contraceptive failure (within 72 h).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** single tablet as soon as possible after intercourse.
- If vomiting within 3 h, repeat dose.
- Start/continue regular contraception immediately (barrier for 7 days for COC).

DOSAGES

- 1.5 mg single dose within 72 h (more effective the sooner taken).
- 3 mg if on enzyme-inducing drugs or BMI >26/weight >70 kg (some guidelines).
- Copper IUD (within 5 days) is the most effective alternative.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Peak:** 2 h. Bioavailability ~100%.
- Metabolised in liver (CYP3A4).
- Excreted in urine and faeces. **t½:** 24–32 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Delays or inhibits ovulation (blocks LH surge).
- Does not disrupt an implanted pregnancy (not an abortifacient).

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Nausea, abdominal pain.
- Headache, fatigue, breast tenderness.
- Irregular bleeding; next period may be early or late.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Ectopic pregnancy if failure occurs (rare).
- Hypersensitivity (rare).

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Known pregnancy (ineffective, not harmful).
- Severe hepatic impairment (caution); acute porphyria.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Enzyme inducers (rifampicin, carbamazepine, efavirenz, St John's wort):** ↓ efficacy — double dose or use copper IUD.
- **Ulipristal:** avoid within 5 days (antagonism).

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Assess timing of intercourse and cycle; offer copper IUD option.
- Pregnancy test if period >7 days late or abnormal bleeding.
- Discuss ongoing contraception and STI testing.
- Safeguarding assessment for young people.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take as soon as possible; effectiveness falls with time.
- Do pregnancy test if next period is late by >7 days or unusual.
- Use condoms until regular contraception is effective; does not protect future acts of intercourse.
- Seek help for severe lower abdominal pain (ectopic).

KEY POINTS

- Single 1.5 mg dose within 72 h.
- Double dose with enzyme inducers.
- Delays ovulation; not abortifacient.
- Copper IUD is more effective.

SOURCES CHECKED **[677]** Levonelle 1500 microgram tablet (UK SmPC) **[678]** My Way, oral (US label)
Full references p. 432–457